



Supplied, Then Penalised

A Two-Wave Classification of Non-Conforming Material in the Paper-Only Recycling Stream

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Motivation

Facilities' Diversion Performance Score marks a building down for contamination found in its paper-only stream. Despite sustained attention to what occupants put in the bin, little is known about what the non-conforming material actually is, or who supplied it.

Research questions

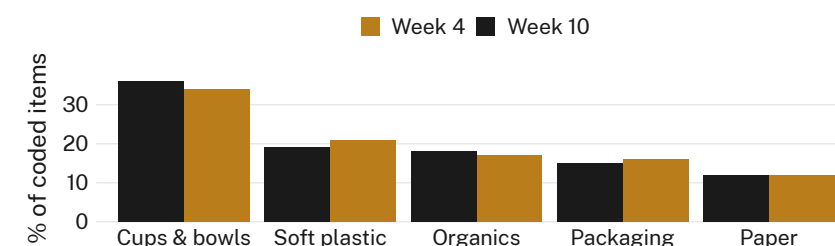
- What classes of material constitute non-conforming items in the paper-only stream?
- Is the class distribution stable across a trimester?
- Which classes originate in University-supplied goods?

Study design

- 1,842 non-conforming items · 9 buildings · two waves (weeks 4 and 10, Trimester 1 2026)
- Hand-sorted to a characterisation bench; coded to a fixed five-class scheme
- 340-item double-coded subsample; $\kappa = 0.84$; coding frame fixed before wave 1

What we found

Disposable cups and bowls supplied under the University's catering contract form the largest class in both waves. The distribution is stable across the trimester, and roughly one item in eight recorded as contamination is conforming paper the auditor coded as non-conforming.



Catering-supplied cups and bowls account for 34% (week 4) and 36% (week 10) of 1,842 coded non-conforming items; no class shifts by more than two percentage points between the two waves.

Interpretation

The Score is levied on the building; the material is bought centrally. A building cannot procure its way out of a contaminant its own campus café hands over the counter. Next: reconcile the coding frame against the catering contract's disposables schedule.

Selected references

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Audits conducted outside occupied hours; material weighed in aggregate, with no bin attributed to an individual office or occupant.

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“The largest contaminant is sold on campus.”

Catering-supplied cups and bowls were the single largest class of non-conforming material in both audit waves ($n = 1,842$ coded items).